

words, sketch out your presentation in “rough mode,” but using actual PowerPoint slides.

A good idea is to use images in place of words where possible. (For example, instead of spelling out, “We are a major player in the international market—we now have a presence in India,” you could use an outline map of the world and of India, and your company logo in the middle of the map of India.) You’re going to be speaking, so the words will come anyway—and on top of that, a picture is worth many words, as they say. This is also important for the reason that if you present an image, your audience can take a quick glance at it and look at you again. As we’ll emphasise later, the focus is you, not the slides.

Tip

It’s common to come up with a grander plan, while ideating, than can be presented. It’s a dilemma: make the presentation longer, or cut down on your ideas? It sounds harsh, but in a situation like this, you’ll have to murder some of what you painstakingly ideated!

How many slides you need is an important point. There are several factors at play here:

1. What kind of presentation is it? A sales report? A proposal for the design of a new product? Research findings? What is typically considered boring, like a sales report, should be as short as can be—possibly 10 slides. What is going to be viewed by a concentrating audience keen to absorb new information can warrant as many as 20.
2. How much time does your audience have? Are they pressed for time, or is it (unfortunately) a Sunday and they just want to get back home, or is it a lovely Wednesday mid-morning session?
3. Who does your audience comprise? This overlaps with point #1. If it’s senior executives, they’re unlikely to be interested in the minutiae. If it’s junior recruits, they might be excited at learning about their new company.